

H1: My Experience Settling in Australia

I moved to Australia in 2001 without knowing a single person.

No family. No contacts. No one who had done it before me to call when things went wrong.

Nobody told me about the hidden bank fees. Nobody warned me about the suburb traps. Nobody explained how Medicare actually worked or in what order to do any of it.

I arrived with one suitcase and a head full of dreams.

Then reality hit.

I couldn't open a bank account without an address. I couldn't get an address without a rental history. And I couldn't have a rental history without having already lived somewhere.

The system wasn't built for people like me.

It was built for people who were already inside it.

I worked jobs I was overqualified for. I signed contracts I didn't fully understand just to have a roof over my head. I sent money home through transfer services that swallowed hundreds in fees.

Every night, alone in a shared house, I used to question my decision.

Life in front of me looked nothing like what I had been promised when I decided to leave home.

Nobody tells you about that part.

What got me through wasn't luck. It was the occasional stranger who took ten minutes to explain how something actually worked. A landlord who gave me a chance. A colleague who referred me to his friend. Small moments of guidance that changed everything and made me realise how much difference the right information at the right time can make.

By 2004 I had permanent residency. By the end of that year, I was an Australian citizen.

But I never forgot how those first years felt.

The confusion. The loneliness. The expensive mistakes made simply because nobody told me the right order to do things.

That's why I built SettleANZ.

Not to repeat what government websites already say.

But to be the person I desperately needed when I arrived, someone who had already walked the same road, made the same mistakes, and could hand you a guide map instead of leaving you to find your own way in the dark.

You worked too hard to get here to spend your first year lost.

I'm here to make sure you don't.

— *Entel*